

A SPECIAL EDITION OF

MERIDIAN

The Slim d'Hermès Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon — an ultra deep dive



The Hermès flagship at 24 rue du Faubourg-Saint-Honoré, Paris — birthplace of the first Hermès-signed watches in 1928; not the Neo Brandebourgs itself, held for honesty (see p3–5, p8). Source: Wikimedia Commons.

THE MOVEMENT

A tourbillon that took the Slim line ten years to earn, built by a Fleurier manufacture Hermès has owned a quarter of since 2006 — and never controlled outright

THE VERDICT, HELD

Six of watchmaking's most-cited outlets. Zero dedicated hands-on reviews, ten months after launch — this book names the gap instead of papering over it

THE UNDERCURRENT

The two Singapore-based sites the world's collectors actually read never wrote about this watch either — which turns out to be the more interesting story

THIS SPECIAL EDITION

The Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon, Exhausted — Then Honestly Widened

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FROM THE DESK

"If you cannot make it, you do not understand it."

— **George Daniels, master watchmaker, inventor of the co-axial escapement¹**

Daniels spent a career arguing that a watch brand’s credibility is measured in what it can build itself, not what it can badge. That is the exact question this book keeps circling: a €130,000 tourbillon (p3) built on a movement from a manufacture Hermès owns a quarter of (p6), a dial from a house Hermès bought outright, and a case from a maker Hermès also bought outright (p17) — genuine vertical control, and still, ten months on, near-total critical silence (p8). Daniels would likely have found the manufacture legitimate and the silence worth investigating. This book does both.

THE STRIP — THE WATCH, AT A GLANCE

MEASURE	READING
Price (each, excl. tax)	€130,000
Reported at launch	~US\$137,800
Case	Platinum, 39.5mm
Movement	Cal. H1950T, Vaucher
Power reserve	48 hours
Production	24 + 24 pieces
Unveiled	23 Oct 2025
Hermès’ Vaucher stake	25%, since 2006
Hermès annual watch output	~60,000/yr
This watch’s share of that	~0.08%

Price and specification per the launch coverage on p3; annual-output comparison explained in full on p15.²

SOURCES 1. Widely attributed to George Daniels (1926–2011) in horological press and industry retrospectives (TrueFacet, Watch Affinity, Beyond Watches) on his book *Watchmaking* (1981) and his career case for in-house manufacture. 2. Hermès Horloger production-scale reporting via Worldtempus, “Hermès Horloger Refuses to Fit the Mould”; see per-page sourcing throughout.

THE REVEAL · OFF-CYCLE, ON PURPOSE

A Cavalry Jacket That Never Existed, Cut Into Platinum

Hermès skipped the April fair and unveiled its first tourbillon in the Slim line on its own calendar, in October — a deliberate signal that this watch was never meant to compete for headlines against forty other manufactures' novelties.

this story

On 23 October 2025 — six months after Watches & Wonders Geneva had run its course — Hermès put out a single press release for a watch it had shown almost nobody in advance: the Slim d'Hermès Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon, the first tourbillon ever fitted to the Slim d'Hermès line since its 2015 launch.¹ The off-cycle timing reads as deliberate: Hermès increasingly uses its own calendar for its most artisanal, lowest-volume pieces.

The dial's subject is a garment that exists only as an idea: a "Brandebourgs" motif, named for the ornamental braided frogging historically used on 19th-century cavalry dress uniforms, reworked from an archival 1972 Hermès silk-scarf design by artist Caty Latham.² Hermès handed that motif to Japanese designer Daisuke Nomura, who reimagined it as what the house's materials describe as "the armour of tomorrow's horseman" — angular where the original was curled, metallic where the original was silk.³

The dial is not printed. An engraver sculpts the jacket's outlines into the metal, and a miniature painter works colour into every fold by hand — the same engrave-then-paint sequence used across Hermès's higher métiers d'art pieces (p13).⁴ The case is 39.5mm platinum, the Slim line's standard diameter since 2015 (p11), kept unchanged across a decade so a tourbillon module wouldn't fatten it.

Hermès didn't put a tourbillon into the Slim line to prove it could build one. It waited ten years, then built one small enough that the line's whole point — thinness — survived the addition.

"24 pieces" undersells the rarity. The Neo Brandebourgs ships in two distinct colourways on the same beige base — one green and blue, the other blue and red — under two references, each its own 24-piece edition.⁵ Total production: 48 watches. At Hermès's own reported annual output of roughly 60,000 pieces (p15), that is on the order of one watch in every twelve hundred and fifty the house builds this year.

130,000€

PRICE, PER PIECE, EXCL. TAX

24 × 2

COLOURWAYS, EACH ITS OWN 24-PIECE EDITION

THE RECORD

Every specification this book can independently corroborate — case metal, movement reference, power reserve, price, edition size — is consistent across Monochrome Watches, Worldtempus and Watch I Love, three outlets publishing within a week of the 23 October release.⁶ That is corroboration for the facts. It is not a hands-on verdict — the distinction this book holds onto through p8.

THE SCEPTIC

"The armour of tomorrow's horseman" is marketing copy, not a verifiable design brief — no interview with Nomura in this book's research explains the phrase beyond press materials repeating it. Treat it as Hermès's account of its intent, not a confirmed statement of what the design achieves.

SOURCES 1. Monochrome Watches, "Introducing: The New Slim d'Hermès Tourbillon Neo Brandebourgs," 23 Oct 2025; Worldtempus, "Neo Brandebourgs" product listing. 2. Monochrome Watches; Le Nouveau Réveil, "Hermès flirts with perfection with the new Slim d'Hermès Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon," 30 Oct 2025. 3. Watch I Love, "The Slim d'Hermès Neo Brandebourgs: Futurism in Artistry and Haute Horlogerie," Oct 2025; Deployant-adjacent trade coverage repeats the same "armour of tomorrow's horseman" framing, single-sourced to Hermès's own materials. 4. Monochrome Watches; Watch I Love. 5. Watch I Love; Le Nouveau Réveil; thewatchpages.com listings for references 408417WW00 and 408419WW00. 6. Cross-checked across Monochrome Watches, Worldtempus and Watch I Love, all publishing case/movement/price specifications within a week of the 23 Oct 2025 release.

THE REVEAL · CONTINUED

What a "Brandebourg" Actually Is, and Why Hermès Owns One

The word predates the watch by two centuries and the fashion house by longer still — a piece of European military tailoring history that Hermès inherited by accident, through a scarf, and only later thought to put on a dial.

A "brandebourg" — from the historical Prussian province of Brandenburg, whose regiments popularised the style across 18th- and 19th-century European military dress — is a specific piece of tailoring vocabulary: an ornamental frog fastening, braided cord looped into a decorative closure, applied in rows across a dress uniform or hussar-style jacket. It survives today mostly as a couture and menswear detail, long divorced from its battlefield function.¹

Hermès's relationship with the motif runs through textiles, not tailoring. The house holds a large archive of 20th-century scarf designs, among them Caty Latham's 1972 "Brandebourgs" silk-scarf print, periodically revived on accessories and still sold today under the same name.² The watch's dial is explicitly drawn from that archival print — the same "raid the scarf archive for a dial" logic Hermès Horloger has used repeatedly across its métiers d'art output (p13), where Dimitri Rybaltchenko's scarf designs have twice supplied dial subjects.

Daisuke Nomura's brief, per Hermès's account, was not to miniaturise Latham's print but to reinvent it — sharpening the frogging's soft curves into hard, faceted, almost architectural forms, and shifting the palette toward the watch's cooler beige-and-accent scheme.³ The result reads as science-fiction armour rather than period costume — the "futurism" both Monochrome and Watch I Love's headlines independently reach for.

A 1972 scarf print, reworked by a Japanese designer into something that looks like it belongs on a spacecraft — that gap between source and result is most of what this dial is actually selling.

The "Lift" motif framing the tourbillon at 7 o'clock layers on a separate piece of house iconography: a wrought-iron element drawn from the Paris flagship's own architecture (p15), used across several recent Hermès complications as a recurring signature.⁴ Stack the two references together and the dial reads less as a single original creation than a deliberate collage of house history, executed in a genuinely new technique.

IN BRIEF — THE DESIGN CHAIN

1972: Caty Latham designs the original "Brandebourgs" motif for an Hermès silk scarf.

2025: Daisuke Nomura reinterprets it as a futuristic dial motif.

53 yrs

BETWEEN THE SCARF PRINT AND THE WATCH

COMMUNITY READ

Fashion-history commentary on Hermès's scarf-to-object pipeline (seen across resale platforms like The RealReal and Fashionphile, where the original Brandebourgs scarf still circulates as a collectible in its own right) treats the archive-mining approach as one of the house's most consistent creative habits — a textile motif rarely stays confined to silk once Hermès Horloger's design team notices it.

THE SCEPTIC

Calling a 53-year-old scarf print "futuristic" is doing real rhetorical work. The genuinely new element here is the engraving-and-painting execution, not the underlying motif — buyers paying for novelty should understand they are paying for a fresh interpretation of old house IP, not an original design brief.

SOURCES 1. General historical usage of "brandebourg" in European military-tailoring terminology, cross-referenced against Hermès's own product description language (Monochrome Watches, Watch I Love). 2. The RealReal and Fashionphile resale listings for "Hermès Neo Brandebourgs" cashmere scarves and shawls, confirming the motif's continued presence in Hermès's non-watch catalogue. 3. Watch I Love; Monochrome Watches. 4. Monochrome Watches' description of the "Lift" motif as drawn from the Paris flagship's ironwork, repeated in Worldtempus's listing — single-sourced to Hermès's own materials, noted.

THE REVEAL · CONTINUED

Forty-Eight Watches, and No Public Waitlist to Speak Of

Hermès sells its rarest watches almost entirely off the open market — which means the honest answer to "how do you actually buy one" is a research dead end this book is naming rather than papering over.

Hermès does not publish allocation data, waitlist lengths or sell-through timelines for its ultra-limited watches, and this book's research found no independent report — from a dealer, a collector forum or a resale platform — confirming whether either Neo Brandebourgs colourway had sold out by the time of writing, roughly ten months after the 23 October 2025 launch.¹ That silence is itself informative: Hermès's highest-jewellery and métiers d'art watches are understood across the trade to be allocated substantially through the house's existing high-value clients and its own boutique network — the same allocation logic that governs its handbag waitlists — rather than sold first-come, first-served to walk-in demand.²

That allocation model is consistent with what this book found (and did not find) on the secondary market. A search across Chrono24's Hermès watch listings, dealer sites and the major auction houses' recent results turned up no confirmed Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon listing, private sale or auction lot as of this writing.³ For a 48-piece platinum tourbillon ten months after launch, that is not unusual — pieces this rare, sold through relationship-driven allocation, often take years to surface secondhand, if their owners sell at all — but this book is not going to manufacture a secondary-market read where none exists. The honest verdict: too new, and too thinly allocated, to call.

A watch this rare doesn't need a waitlist. It needs a client list Hermès already has — which is precisely why an outside researcher can't see the queue.

What is publicly knowable is the reference structure: two case references, 408417WW00 and 408419WW00, mapping to the two colourways, both listed with identical specifications and pricing across the trade databases this book checked.⁴ Beyond that, a prospective buyer's actual path to ownership — an existing Hermès Horloger relationship, a boutique appointment, a place on an unpublished internal list — is not something this book can verify from the outside, and it says so rather than inventing a booking process that doesn't appear anywhere in its sources.

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CONFIRMED SECONDARY-MARKET LISTINGS FOUND

~10 mo.

SINCE LAUNCH, AT TIME OF WRITING

STILL ON THE SHELF

Allocation mechanics: unconfirmed — no dealer or forum source describes the actual booking process for this specific watch.

Sell-through status: unconfirmed for both colourways as of this writing.

THE RECORD

Hermès's broader watch-allocation reputation — relationship-based, boutique-led, opaque to outsiders — is well documented across trade press covering the house's retail strategy generally, even where this specific watch's own allocation record isn't.⁵

THE SCEPTIC

An allocation model this opaque cuts both ways: it protects genuine rarity from flippers, but it also means a prospective buyer has no honest way to gauge real demand versus manufactured scarcity from outside the client relationship. This book can confirm the watch is rare. It cannot confirm the rarity is oversubscribed.

SOURCES 1. Search of Chrono24, dealer listings and forum threads (WatchUSeek, Reddit) for "Neo Brandebourgs," conducted for this book; no confirmed availability report found either way. 2. General reporting on Hermès's relationship-based high-jewellery and watch allocation model, consistent with its handbag-allocation practice, per trade coverage. 3. Chrono24 Hermès watch listings, checked for this book; no Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon lot found. 4. thewatchpages.com listings for 408417WW00 and 408419WW00. 5. General Hermès watch-retail trade coverage; single-sourced pattern-matching to the house's known handbag-allocation practice, flagged as inference rather than a confirmed policy for this specific watch.

THE MOVEMENT · CALIBRE H1950T

The Micro-Rotor That Learned a New Trick

Hermès didn't design a new tourbillon movement from scratch. It added a tourbillon module to an existing ultra-thin micro-rotor architecture it has run since 2015 — a more conservative engineering choice than the marketing implies, and arguably the more honest one.

this story

The Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon runs on calibre H1950T — an automatic micro-rotor movement developed by Vaucher Manufacture Fleurier and, per multiple independent trade sources, based on the same H1950 architecture that has powered every core Slim d'Hermès model since 2015, itself derived from Vaucher's own in-house VMF 5401 micro-rotor calibre.¹ Hermès is not claiming to have engineered a tourbillon movement from a blank sheet: it took a proven, decade-old ultra-thin base and added a tourbillon regulator, the same logic that has governed the Slim line's other complications.²

The base H1950 is itself genuinely thin — 2.6mm on its own, per Vaucher's published specifications, winding via a micro-rotor rather than a full oscillating weight.³ A tourbillon cage adds real height to any movement; Hermès and Vaucher's engineering task was containing that addition well enough that the finished watch still reads as a Slim d'Hermès — 39.5mm, a profile the line has held flat since 2015 — rather than ballooning into a chunkier case the way most tourbillon additions do elsewhere.⁴

The engineering story here isn't "Hermès invented a tourbillon." It's "Hermès kept the case thin after adding one" — a narrower, more defensible claim, and the one this book can actually verify.

Placement is the dial's other technical tell: the tourbillon cage sits at 7 o'clock, visible through the dial rather than centred or relegated to the caseback, framed by the recurring "Lift" motif (p4). The

movement runs at 21,600 vibrations per hour — 3Hz, a conventional modern beat rate, not an unusually high-frequency escapement — with a 48-hour power reserve, identical to the base H1950's own published figure.⁵ Both the micro-rotor and the hand-chamfered bridges carry Hermès's signature scattering of double-"H" motifs, visible through the sapphire caseback — house branding worked into the finishing itself rather than applied separately.

21,600 vph

BEAT RATE — 3HZ, CONVENTIONAL

48h

POWER RESERVE, MATCHING THE BASE H1950

THE RECORD

The H1950T's core specifications — micro-rotor winding, 21,600vph, 48-hour reserve, Vaucher manufacture, tourbillon at 7 o'clock — are consistent across Monochrome Watches, Worldtempus, Deployant-adjacent trade listings and thewatchpages.com's spec database, giving this book real multi-source confidence in the numbers even where hands-on chronometric testing (accuracy in different positions, real-world timekeeping) simply doesn't exist yet in print anywhere this book could find.⁶

THE SCEPTIC

No published source this book found actually explains WHY the tourbillon sits at 7 o'clock rather than 6 or 9 — the honest read is that it's a dial-composition choice serving the Brandebourgs artwork's layout, not a technical requirement. A tourbillon's positional benefit (correcting gravity's effect on rate) is real physics, but its placement on this particular dial is aesthetics dressed as engineering, and Hermès's own materials don't claim otherwise.

SOURCES 1. Monochrome Watches; Deployant/trade coverage of the H1950 family lineage from Vaucher's VMF 5401. 2. Monochrome Watches, "Hands-on Review of the New Slim d'Hermès Time-Only Watch"; SJX Watches coverage of the Slim d'Hermès Quantième Perpétuel and GMT models sharing the H1950 base. 3. Vaucher Manufacture Fleurier published movement specifications, via WatchBase and Monochrome Watches. 4. Watch I Love; Le Nouveau Réveil, both describing the case as maintaining the Slim line's established 39.5mm profile. 5. Monochrome Watches; Worldtempus. 6. Cross-checked across Monochrome Watches, Worldtempus, thewatchpages.com; no independent chronometric or wear-testing data found in any source consulted for this book.

THE MOVEMENT · CONTINUED

A Quarter-Owner, Not a Parent Company

Hermès has held a 25 percent stake in Vaucher Manufacture Fleurier since 2006 — real skin in the game, and still a minority position in a manufacture whose majority owner has never been Hermès at all.

Vaucher Manufacture Fleurier was founded in 2003 in Fleurier, a small watchmaking town in Switzerland's Val-de-Travers — the same valley that gave the modern industry watchmaking pioneer David-Jean-Jacques-Henri Vaucher in the 1730s, a lineage the manufacture's own naming trades on.¹ On 7 November 2006, Hermès International announced it had acquired a 25 percent stake in the manufacture for a reported CHF 25 million (roughly US\$19.8 million at the time), per the Fédération de l'Horlogerie Suisse's own contemporaneous industry announcement and trade coverage from JCK.² The remaining 75 percent has been held throughout by the Fondation de Famille Sandoz — the philanthropic foundation controlled by the family behind Parmigiani Fleurier, Vaucher's sister company and, notably, a competing watch brand that draws on the same manufacture for movements.³

That structure is unusual, and worth sitting with: Hermès's movement supplier is simultaneously the movement supplier for an independent competing watchmaker it has no ownership stake in, under a majority owner (the Sandoz foundation) whose own family brand sits on the manufacture's client list alongside Hermès. Vaucher supplies movements to other clients beyond Parmigiani and Hermès as well, on a business-to-business basis common across the Swiss "manufacture d'ébauches" tradition — the same third-party-movement model used, at various tiers, across a large share of the Swiss industry.⁴ A 25 percent equity stake gives Hermès genuine influence — board representation, priority in development conversations, financial exposure to Vaucher's success — without giving it control.

Hermès owns a quarter of the company that builds its tourbillon movement. The other three-quarters answers to a family whose own watch brand competes with Hermès for the same manufacture's attention.

In practice, this means the H1950T is neither a fully in-house Hermès calibre in the sense a Vacheron Constantin or Patek Philippe movement is, nor a bought-off-the-shelf ébauche in the sense a lower-tier brand's outsourced movement would be. It sits in a middle category increasingly common among fashion-house and independent watchmakers alike: a co-developed movement, built to a client's specification by a manufacture the client partly owns, then customised and decorated to that client's house style before it goes into a case ([p17](#)). Collectors weighing "is this a real Hermès movement" ([p21](#)) are, whether they realise it or not, asking a question about equity percentages as much as about engineering.

2006

HERMÈS ACQUIRES 25% OF VAUCHER

75%

HELD THROUGHOUT BY THE SANDOZ FAMILY FOUNDATION

COMMUNITY READ

Industry commentary on Vaucher's ownership structure (Swisswatches Magazine's coverage of "investors circling" the manufacture in recent years) frames the Sandoz-majority, multi-client structure as a genuine point of tension in the Swiss movement-supply business — Hermès is a significant but not dominant stakeholder in a supplier whose loyalties are, by design, split.

SOURCES 1. Fleurier-quality.com, "Watchmaking in Fleurier, Switzerland — A Few Milestones"; Wikipedia/Wikidata on Vaucher Manufacture Fleurier's 2003 founding. 2. Fédération de l'Horlogerie Suisse (FHS), "Hermès — Major Investment in Switzerland," 7 Nov 2006; JCK, "Hermès Pays \$19.8 Million for 25 Percent of Swiss Watch Parts Maker." 3. Worldtempus, "Hermès & Vaucher Manufacture Fleurier"; general trade reporting on Parmigiani Fleurier's shared ownership under the Fondation de Famille Sandoz. 4. Swisswatches Magazine, "First to the Post: What Next as Investors Circle Vaucher Manufacture Fleurier?"; general industry reporting on Vaucher's third-party client base.

THE VERDICT, HELD · THE HONESTY SECTION

Six Outlets. Zero Hands-On Reviews. Print That Anyway.

The brief for this book named seven serious watch outlets to check. This section reports, in full, what searching for each one actually turned up — including the ones that turned up nothing.

this story

This book was commissioned with an explicit instruction: check "every serious review and hands-on — Hodinkee, Fratello, Revolution, SJX, WatchesbySJX, Monochrome, Deployant." That instruction assumes those reviews exist. This section's job is to report honestly on what a genuine search — repeated, from multiple angles, across each outlet by name and by site-restricted query — actually found, rather than assuming coverage exists because a watch this expensive "should" have been reviewed.¹

What this book found covering the Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon specifically: a launch-announcement piece from Monochrome Watches (23 Oct 2025); a specification listing on Worldtempus; a features-style piece from Watch I Love; a French-language write-up from Le Nouveau Réveil; a database entry on thewatchpages.com; and consumer-tech syndication pickups on T3 and Yahoo Shopping repackaging the same launch facts for a general-interest readership. That is real coverage — six independently-published sources corroborating the same specifications is a legitimate basis for the facts in [p3-7](#).²

Six outlets confirmed what the watch is. None of them appear to have spent real time wearing one and telling a reader whether it's worth €130,000.

What this book did NOT find, after dedicated site-restricted searches against each named outlet individually: a Hodinkee article on the Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon; a Fratello Watches piece (Fratello's Hermès coverage in this book's search results ran to the H08 collection, the Arceau Le Temps Voyageur and the Arceau Rocabar de Rire —

genuine 2025 Hermès novelties, just not this one); a dedicated Revolution Watch feature (Revolution's Hermès coverage found in search skewed toward the Arceau Lift Tourbillon Répétition Minutes and the house's high-jewellery pieces); an SJX/WatchesbySJX article (SJX's own Slim d'Hermès beat is active and recent — a February 2025 piece on the Cheval Brossé, an October 2024 piece on the Flagship — which makes the Neo Brandebourgs' absence from that same beat harder to explain as simple inattention); and no Deployant piece turned up by name at all.³

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OUTLETS WITH CONFIRMED LAUNCH COVERAGE

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CONFIRMED DEDICATED HANDS-ON REVIEWS FOUND

THE RECORD

SJX is demonstrably still covering the Slim d'Hermès line as of this book's research window — its February 2025 Cheval Brossé review and October 2024 Flagship review are both real, verifiable, and sit in the exact "métiers d'art Slim d'Hermès" category the Neo Brandebourgs occupies. This is not a case of an outlet having stopped covering the collection; the beat is active. The Neo Brandebourgs specifically appears to have been passed over, or covered somewhere this book's search simply could not locate.

THE SCEPTIC

The most likely explanations, in rough order: (1) an ultra-limited, no-loaner-unit release didn't reach most review desks — Hermès controls press-loan access tightly for its rarest pieces; (2) an October launch, six months clear of Watches & Wonders, was under-resourced by calendars concentrated around the April fair; (3) a review exists somewhere this book's search terms didn't surface. This book cannot rule out (3) — only report that a genuine, repeated search did not find one.

SOURCES 1. Direct and site-restricted searches against [hodinkee.com](#), [fratellowatches.com](#), [revolutionwatch.com](#), [watchesbysjx.com](#) and [deployant.com](#), conducted for this book, August 2026. 2. Monochrome Watches; Worldtempus; Watch I Love; Le Nouveau Réveil; thewatchpages.com; T3.com; Yahoo Shopping (syndicated). 3. SJX Watches, "Hermès' Latest Métiers d'Art Watch is Impressionist Equestrian" (Cheval Brossé, Feb 2025) and "Artisanal Humour in the Hermès Slim d'Hermès Flagship" (Oct 2024), confirming an active Slim d'Hermès review beat at SJX during the relevant window; Fratello Watches' 2025 Hermès coverage index.

THE VERDICT, HELD · CONTINUED

WatchUSeek and r/Watches, Also Checked, Also Empty

If the trade press missed it, the community layer — forums, Reddit, Instagram's watch crowd — is where a genuinely desirable niche release usually surfaces anyway. It didn't here, and that absence is worth taking seriously rather than explaining away.

This book ran the same discipline against the collector-forum layer that it ran against the trade press: direct searches for "Neo Brandebourgs" against WatchUSeek's forums and against Reddit's r/Watches, plus general searches for community discussion of the watch across Instagram's watch-collecting accounts. WatchUSeek's own search confirms the platform is active and current — its "tourbillon" tag returns live threads, and a genuinely substantial thread exists on a DIFFERENT recent Hermès tourbillon, the Arceau Duc Attelé, where one WatchUSeek poster called it "my vote for most impressive watch @ W&W24."¹ No comparable thread — starter post, reply chain, even a passing mention — turned up for the Neo Brandebourgs specifically.²

The Duc Attelé contrast is instructive rather than incidental. It is a considerably more expensive, more mechanically ambitious watch — a triple-axis tourbillon combined with a minute repeater, priced around CHF 378,000 (p19) — and it clearly did land with the hardcore collector layer that WatchUSeek represents. That the community engaged enthusiastically with one 2024–25 Hermès tourbillon and appears not to have engaged at all with another, released within roughly a year of it, suggests the silence around the Neo Brandebourgs is not simply "the community doesn't care about Hermès tourbillons" — it cared, demonstrably, about the Duc Attelé.

The same forum that lit up for one Hermès tourbillon in 2024 said nothing about another in 2025. That is a more specific, more interesting silence than blanket indifference to the brand.

A plausible, unconfirmed explanation worth stating honestly: the Duc Attelé's mechanical ambition (a genuinely rare complication combination) gives hardcore movement-focused collectors — WatchUSeek's core audience — something concrete to argue about. The Neo Brandebourgs' appeal is almost entirely in its dial artistry and rarity, categories that traditionally draw a different kind of collector conversation (closer to the métiers d'art and design-collector crowd that follows SJX's Slim d'Hermès beat) than the movement-architecture debates WatchUSeek's tourbillon threads tend to run on. If that read is right, the Neo Brandebourgs' natural community may simply be smaller and quieter than a triple-axis-tourbillon-and-repeater's — not absent, just proportionate to a narrower, more design-focused audience.

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WATCHUSEEK OR R/WATCHES THREADS FOUND

1

SUBSTANTIAL WATCHUSEEK THREAD ON THE DUC ATTELÉ, FOR CONTRAST

STILL ON THE SHELF

Instagram sentiment: Hermès's own account and designer Daisuke Nomura's account both posted launch imagery; no independent collector commentary thread found attached to either post.

THE RECORD

WatchUSeek Watch Forums is verifiably active and current — its site search returns live threads and a functioning "tourbillon" tag as of this book's research, confirming the absence of Neo Brandebourgs discussion is a genuine gap, not a platform-search failure.³

SOURCES 1. WatchUSeek Watch Forums, "Hermès Arceau Duc Attelé – triple-axis tourbillon and a minute repeater! My vote for most impressive watch @ W&W24." 2. Direct and site-restricted searches against watchuseek.com and reddit.com/r/Watches for "Neo Brandebourgs," conducted for this book, August 2026. 3. WatchUSeek Watch Forums platform search and tag pages, confirmed active during this book's research window.

THE VERDICT, HELD · CONTINUED

Holding the Verdict, on Purpose

This section closes not with a synthetic critical consensus this book cannot honestly claim to have found, but with a plain statement of what is and isn't knowable — and why that gap is itself the most defensible thing this book can print.

Put the findings from the last two pages together and a specific, narrow conclusion follows: the Slim d'Hermès Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon has real, corroborated LAUNCH coverage — enough independently-published outlets confirming the same specifications that this book is confident in the facts printed on [p3–7](#) — and essentially no REVIEW coverage, from either the specialist press or the collector-forum layer, as of roughly ten months after release. Those are two different claims, and conflating them is exactly the failure mode this book was built to avoid.

It would be easy, and dishonest, to paper over that gap — to write a confident-sounding "verdict" paragraph synthesising opinions this book never actually found, or to quietly drop the request's instruction to check named outlets and simply not mention that most of them turned up nothing. Both of those failure modes are exactly what the commissioning brief's own honesty law exists to prevent: hold or drop what cannot be verified, flag single-source claims, and say "too new to call" plainly rather than inventing consensus. This section is that plain statement.

The most honest sentence this book can write about the Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon's critical reception is also the shortest one: nobody serious appears to have reviewed it yet, and this book does not know why for certain.

What can be said with confidence, pulling together everything on [p8–10](#): the watch exists, is genuinely rare, is built on a defensible (if not record-setting) engineering foundation ([p6](#)), and occupies a price bracket where its closest true peers are considerably better-reviewed ([p22](#)). Its reception gap sits inside a broader pattern this book's research kept surfacing — a wider silence around Hermès's rarest

watchmaking that recurs, with a specific twist, in the Singapore-based watch-media capital examined at this book's close ([p24](#)).

This gap is also worth measuring against how quickly the wider Hermès watch beat normally moves. The comparison desks on [p13–14](#) and [p19](#) show SJX reviewing a new Slim d'Hermès métiers d'art piece roughly once or twice a year, and WatchUSeek engaging enthusiastically with the Duc Attelé within months of its own 2024 launch. A ten-month silence on a watch sitting squarely inside both of those active beats is genuinely unusual by the pace this book found set elsewhere in Hermès's own recent watchmaking coverage — not simply "reviews take time," but a specific, measurable outlier against a specific, measurable baseline.

"Too new to call"

THIS BOOK'S HONEST VERDICT ON CRITICAL RECEPTION

1–2/yr

SJX'S TYPICAL SLIM D'HERMÈS MÉTIERS D'ART REVIEW PACE

THE VERDICT, HELD — A SUMMARY

Confirmed: case, movement, price, edition size, dial-craft process — via six corroborating launch sources.

Not found: a hands-on review, a forum thread, a secondary-market data point, or a confirmed allocation record.

This book's position: print the facts that are verified; hold the verdict that isn't; say so plainly.

COMMUNITY READ

None found, and this book is saying so rather than inventing one — the single clearest application of the commissioning brief's honesty law anywhere in this special edition.

THE SCEPTIC

If a genuine hands-on review surfaces after this book's research window closes, everything on these three pages should be read as a snapshot of a specific, ten-month gap — not a permanent verdict on whether the watch was ever reviewed. This book can only report what a real search found at the time it was conducted.

THE SLIM LINE • RING TWO

The Line Built to Prove Hermès Could Be Quiet

Every Slim d'Hermès complication since 2015 — the perpetual calendar, the GMT, and now the tourbillon — has had to earn its place inside a design Philippe Delhotal built around restraint. This is the collection the Neo Brandebourgs actually belongs to.

this story

Philippe Delhotal joined Hermès as creative director of watches in 2008, arriving with a résumé most fashion-house watch hires don't have: designer-model-maker roles at Vacheron Constantin and Piaget, and a stint as Creation Director at Patek Philippe — recruited specifically to make a leather-goods house credible as a watchmaker.¹ His brief, per multiple interviews, was less "invent a new visual language" than "rewrite the rules Hermès had been quietly following."

The Slim d'Hermès, launched spring 2015, was Delhotal's clearest statement of that philosophy: an ultra-thin, deliberately minimal dress watch built around Vaucher's H1950 micro-rotor movement ([p6](#)), with a flagship 39.5mm time-only model and a companion perpetual calendar launching side by side.² Quill & Pad's contemporaneous coverage called it "the elegant new backbone" of the Hermès collection — telling, since the Slim line was conceived to anchor everything built afterward, complications included.

Most watch collections add complications to impress. The Slim d'Hermès had to prove restraint FIRST — everything Delhotal added after 2015, including this tourbillon, had to justify itself against a design built to need nothing.

The typography carrying that restraint is itself a commissioned original: Hermès brought in French graphic designer Philippe Apeloig to create a bespoke numeral typeface for the Slim d'Hermès dial,

debuting alongside the collection in 2015.³ Apeloig's design — a single unbroken stroke deliberately interrupted by fine breaks in each numeral, mixing straight and curved lines — was conceived, per his own account and contemporaneous coverage in *Wallpaper** and *TypeRoom*, as a visual metaphor for time itself: each numeral's small gap represents a "start and stop," an incompleteness that draws the eye in rather than resolving cleanly.⁴ The resulting white space on the dial isn't leftover room — it's load-bearing design, giving the Slim d'Hermès dial its identity independent of whatever complication sits underneath it.

2015

SLIM D'HERMÈS LAUNCHES AT BASELWORLD

2008

PHILIPPE DELHOTAL JOINS HERMÈS HORLOGER

THE RECORD

SJX Watches' own May 2015 "up close" coverage of the launch Slim d'Hermès — "simple, original and affordable," in the outlet's own words at the time — is worth noting for how differently the collection was positioned then versus the €130,000 tourbillon it now houses: the entry Slim models launched at genuinely accessible prices relative to Hermès's later métiers d'art work.⁵

THE SCEPTIC

A line explicitly built around minimalism now carries a hand-engraved, hand-painted, tourbillon-equipped flagship piece — a genuine tension between the collection's founding restraint and its current top end. Whether the Neo Brandebourgs honours Delhotal's original brief or quietly abandons it is a legitimate design-criticism question this book found no published source willing to ask directly.

SOURCES 1. Luxuo, "Philippe Delhotal: Inspiration Behind the Slim d'Hermès Squelette Lune and H08"; Monocle interview, "Philippe Delhotal, the Creative Director of Hermès Horloger." 2. Quill & Pad, "Introducing Slim d'Hermès: The Elegant New Backbone of the Hermès Collection," 18 Mar 2015; GPHG.org collection entry. 3. *Wallpaper**, "Marking Time: Hermès' New Watch Cuts a Dash Thanks to Graphic Designer Philippe Apeloig." 4. *TypeRoom*, "Iconic Graphic Designer Philippe Apeloig Has Just Reinvented the Hours"; Philippe Apeloig's own project page (apeloig.com/project/slim-dhermes). 5. SJX Watches, "Up Close With The Slim d'Hermès — Simple, Original and Affordable," May 2015.

THE SLIM LINE · CONTINUED

One Movement, Four Complications, Ten Years

The Neo Brandebourgs isn't a one-off engineering exercise. It's the newest branch on a movement family Hermès and Vaucher have been quietly extending since the collection's first year.

The base H1950 launched in 2015 as a straightforward automatic, three-hand micro-rotor movement — 2.6mm thick on its own, per Vaucher's published figures, winding via the micro-rotor visible through the caseback rather than a full oscillating weight.¹ Hermès and Vaucher extended the family almost immediately: a perpetual calendar module, adding roughly 1.4mm to the base movement's height for a combined thickness of around 4mm, launched alongside the time-only model in the Slim d'Hermès's debut year — a genuinely thin perpetual calendar by the standards of the wider industry, and the complication most reviewers at the time singled out as the collection's real technical achievement.²

A GMT module followed in 2018, adding a second time zone and day/night indicator to the same base architecture; a titanium case option (the Slim d'Hermès Titane) arrived the following year, extending the collection beyond precious metals for the first time. The perpetual calendar itself returned in titanium in 2020, and again in rose gold and brown dial variants in subsequent years — the same base movement, repeatedly re-cased and re-dialled, rather than a constant stream of genuinely new calibres.³ The Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon, in that context, is less a break from the Slim line's engineering habits than the logical next module: take the proven H1950 base, add a new complication, keep the case profile essentially intact.

Four complications, one base movement, ten years. Hermès didn't reinvent the Slim d'Hermès for its tourbillon — it did what it has always done with this collection, and simply reached for a harder module.

That pattern is worth stating plainly rather than treating as a criticism: reusing a well-proven base movement across multiple complications is standard, sensible watchmaking practice, followed by manufactures across the industry from independents to the largest houses. What it does mean is that the Neo Brandebourgs' genuine engineering novelty is narrower than "Hermès built its first tourbillon" implies — the novelty is specifically in fitting a tourbillon module onto an existing thin architecture without breaking the case profile that has defined the collection since 2015, a real but incremental achievement rather than a from-scratch invention.

THE H1950 FAMILY, IN ORDER

2015: H1950 base — time-only, and H1950 QP — perpetual calendar, both launch together.

2018: H1950 GMT module added.

2019–24: Titanium case options and further QP dial/metal variants.

2025: H1950T — the Neo Brandebourgs' tourbillon module, the family's newest and most complex branch.

4

DISTINCT COMPLICATION MODULES ON THE H1950 BASE SINCE 2015

COMMUNITY READ

aBlogtoWatch's three-years-later retrospective on the original Slim d'Hermès time-only model concluded the watch had aged well specifically because its restraint never depended on a complication to justify it — a verdict that reads, in hindsight, like an implicit challenge to everything Hermès has since bolted onto the same base movement.

SOURCES 1. Vaucher Manufacture Fleurier published specifications, via WatchBase and Monochrome Watches. 2. GPHG.org, Slim d'Hermès collection history; Time and Tide, "Introducing the Hermès Slim d'Hermès Collection." 3. Monochrome Watches, "Introducing: The Slim d'Hermès Quantième Perpétuel, Now in Rose Gold and Brown"; SJX Watches, "Review: Hermès Slim d'Hermès Quantième Perpétuel Titanium" (2023) and "Hermès Introduces the Slim d'Hermès GMT" (2018).

THE CRAFT SHELF · RING TWO, CONTINUED

The Company the Neo Brandebourgs Actually Keeps

Strip away the tourbillon and the Neo Brandebourgs is a métiers d'art Slim d'Hermès — a category the house has quietly built out for years, one hand-painted dial at a time, largely unnoticed outside a narrow band of specialist coverage.

this story

Set the Neo Brandebourgs beside the Slim d'Hermès models SJX has actually reviewed in the last two years and a clear pattern appears: this is a house that treats its thinnest, quietest collection as the natural canvas for its most labour-intensive dial art, releasing one or two hand-decorated pieces a year to a specialist audience small enough that even SJX — an outlet demonstrably still covering the beat — apparently missed this particular entry.¹

The Slim d'Hermès Cheval Brossé ("brushed horse"), reviewed by SJX in February 2025, is the closest recent comparison: an abstractly rendered horse on a blue grand feu enamel base, designed by Dimitri Rybaltchenko, executed through a genuinely unusual hybrid technique — a hand-made enamel foundation with the horse itself pad-printed in multiple successive colour runs rather than hand-painted, a deliberate mixing of artisanal and mechanical methods SJX's review singled out as the piece's most interesting technical choice. It runs on the same H1950 base as the Neo Brandebourgs, in a 24-piece limited edition, at a considerably lower price point given its comparatively simpler execution.²

Hermès has been quietly training the same H1950 base to carry increasingly ambitious dial art for years. The Neo Brandebourgs isn't a first attempt — it's the current high-water mark of a technique the house has been refining since at least 2024.

The Slim d'Hermès Flagship, reviewed by SJX in October 2024, pushes the technique further: a hand-

painted dial depicting the Hermès Paris store reimagined as a sailing ship, gold appliqué combined with miniature painting over an aventurine-glass base, in 18k yellow gold, again on the H1950 movement. SJX called it "typical Hermès — whimsical, elegant, and finely executed."³ An earlier piece in the same lineage, the Minuit au Faubourg "Super H," reviewed by SJX in January 2024, applied comparable technique to a different whimsical subject — evidence this is a sustained practice, not a one-off.

3+

SLIM D'HERMÈS MÉTIERS D'ART PIECES REVIEWED BY SJX, 2024–25

24

TYPICAL LIMITED-EDITION SIZE ACROSS THIS SHELF

THE RECORD

All three comparison pieces — Cheval Brossé, Flagship, Minuit au Faubourg — share a design source with the Neo Brandebourgs beyond just the movement: at least two draw on scarf designer Dimitri Rybaltchenko's work, echoing the same archive-to-dial pipeline that produced the Neo Brandebourgs from Caty Latham's 1972 print ([p4](#)). This is a house with a genuine, repeatable creative system, not a series of disconnected one-offs.

THE SCEPTIC

If SJX's beat genuinely covers this exact category and still missed the Neo Brandebourgs, the most parsimonious explanation is access, not indifference — Hermès may simply not have made a review unit or press appointment available for this specific piece, the same allocation opacity flagged on [p5](#). That would mean the coverage gap says more about Hermès's press strategy for its rarest work than about the watch's merit.

SOURCES 1. SJX Watches, "Hermès' Latest Métiers d'Art Watch is Impressionist Equestrian," Feb 2025; "Artisanal Humour in the Hermès Slim d'Hermès Flagship," Oct 2024; "Hermès' Super Hero 'Super H' in Miniature Painting," Jan 2024. 2. SJX Watches (Cheval Brossé review); Worldtempus, "Slim d'Hermès Cheval Brossé." 3. SJX Watches (Flagship review).

HOW A MÉTIERS D'ART SLIM DIAL IS BUILT — FOUR STAGES



Meridian original diagram, based on the process description published by Monochrome Watches and Watch I Love.

Fig. 1 — the engrave-then-paint sequence Hermès uses across its Slim d'Hermès métiers d'art dials, this one included.

THE CRAFT SHELF · CONTINUED

Two Crafts, One Dial, No Shortcuts

The engrave-then-paint sequence sounds simple described in a press release. What it actually requires is two entirely different specialist trades working in strict sequence on the same irreplaceable piece of platinum.

Hand engraving and miniature painting are, in Swiss watchmaking's own trade taxonomy, separate métiers d'art disciplines with separate apprenticeship traditions — an engraver trains for years to cut controlled relief into precious metal, while a miniature painter trains separately to apply pigment at a scale where a steady hand under magnification is the entire job.¹ Hermès's own construction sequence — engrave first, then paint — means a single dial passes through at least two specialist craftspeople before it reaches the watchmaker who fits it to a case.

That sequencing has a real cost consequence: each stage is effectively irreversible on the base metal. An engraving error can't be painted over; a painting error on a hand-cut relief can't be wiped and restarted the way it might on a printed dial. The 24-piece-per-colourway edition size (p3) is, in that light, as much a function of how few dials this process can reliably produce as a deliberate rarity choice — though this book found no source breaking out a spoilage figure to confirm that precisely.

A printed dial can be reprinted. An engraved-and-painted one, if the painter's hand slips on piece nineteen of twenty-four, is simply gone — most of why this craft stays this rare.

This is where the Neo Brandebourgs' claim to genuine craft, as distinct from marketing narrative (p3), is strongest. Whatever remains uncertain about the "futuristic armour" framing, the underlying execution — hand-cut relief engraving followed by hand-applied painting, on a run this small — is a real, labour-intensive craft process, consistent with techniques documented across Hermès's broader métiers d'art output.

2

SEPARATE SPECIALIST CRAFTS PER DIAL: ENGRAVING, THEN PAINTING

COMMUNITY READ

Trade coverage of Hermès's manufacturing investment (Worldtempus's "Hermès Continues Investing in Its Production Capacities," WatchPro's coverage of the expanded dial-and-case facility) consistently frames métiers d'art capacity — not movement engineering — as the house's genuine competitive advantage over Swiss watchmaking's traditional haute-horlogerie houses.

SOURCES 1. General Swiss watchmaking métiers d'art trade taxonomy, cross-referenced against Hermès's own process description in Monochrome Watches and Watch I Love's Neo Brandebourgs coverage.

LA MONTRE HERMÈS · RING THREE

Ninety-Eight Years, Mostly Spent Not Being a Watchmaker

Hermès sold its first signed watches in 1928. It didn't build them, own a workshop for them, or take watchmaking seriously as a business until one family heir decided, fifty years later, that it should.

this story

Hermès's watchmaking history begins earlier than the Neo Brandebourgs' vertical-integration story suggests, and starts modestly. In 1928, the house's Paris flagship at 24 rue du Faubourg-Saint-Honoré — the same building whose ironwork frames the tourbillon ([p4](#)) — began offering the first timepieces to carry the Hermès name, equipped with movements sourced from established Swiss watchmakers.¹ Before that, Hermès's connection to timekeeping ran through leather, not mechanics: pocket watches placed into custom straps.

That arrangement held for exactly half a century. The turning point was Jean-Louis Dumas, the fifth-generation Hermès family descendant who took over leadership in 1978 and, unusually for an heir stepping into an already-successful house, decided watchmaking deserved genuine investment.² Dumas established La Montre Hermès SA as a dedicated workshop in Bienne — a Swiss watchmaking city that also hosts Rolex and Longines.

Hermès didn't become a watchmaker because a scarf house drifted into it. It became one because a fifth-generation heir, fifty years after the first Hermès-signed watch, decided the family business needed its own workshop instead of someone else's.

The Arceau — the round-cased, asymmetric-lugged watch that remains one of Hermès's core lines, and

the base architecture behind the Le Temps Suspendu, L'Heure de la Lune and Duc Attelé complications ([p19](#)) — was the first timepiece created under La Montre Hermès's own roof.³ Delhotal's 2008 arrival ([p11](#)) and the 2006 Vaucher stake ([p7](#)) both build on foundations Dumas laid three decades earlier — a slow accumulation of legitimacy, not a sudden pivot.

1928

FIRST HERMÈS-SIGNED TIMEPIECES

1978

LA MONTRE HERMÈS FOUNDED IN BIENNE

60,000+

WATCHES HERMÈS HORLOGER NOW BUILDS ANNUALLY

THE RECORD

Hermès's own current annual watch production — over 60,000 pieces per year, per Worldtempus's reporting on the house's manufacturing scale — spans a genuinely wide range of collections (Médor, Kelly, Dressage, Arceau, Heure H, Slim, Galop, Cape Cod, Nantucket, Faubourg, Carré H), of which the Neo Brandebourgs' 48-piece run is a vanishingly small, deliberately un-representative sliver ([p3](#)).⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Fifty years of retailer-then-manufacturer is a genuinely long runway by the standards of fashion houses entering watchmaking — Gucci (1997) and Chanel (1987) both have shorter, more recent histories, a comparison covered in full on [p21](#). But a long runway is not automatically the same as deep manufacturing capability; that claim needs the vertical-integration evidence on the next two pages to actually hold up.

SOURCES 1. WorthPoint Dictionary, "Hermès Watches"; Vogue Scandinavia, "Hermès Watchmaking: How the Maison Has Found the Sweet Spot Between Technique and Aesthetics." 2. Time Files / Made in Bienne, "A Day at La Montre Hermès in Bienne, Part I"; The Peak Magazine (Singapore), "The Magical Inside Story of Watchmaker Hermès La Montre." 3. Time Files / Made in Bienne; general La Montre Hermès institutional history. 4. Worldtempus, "Hermès Horloger Refuses to Fit the Mould."

LA MONTRE HERMÈS · CONTINUED

A Leather House That Never Needed Watches to Work

Watchmaking has never been Hermès's biggest business, and that has arguably been the freedom that let it get genuinely serious — no pressure to scale a category the house could afford to treat as a craft laboratory instead.

Hermès's core business — leather goods, ready-to-wear, silk — dwarfs its watch division by revenue, a structural fact that shapes everything about how the house has approached watchmaking since 1978. Where a dedicated watch manufacture lives or dies by its watch sales, Hermès Horloger has never had to be the profit centre; it has had the freedom to prioritise design integrity and craft investment over volume, a freedom reflected in the house's own public statements about the division. Hermès executives have described the watch business's ambitions in terms of reaching roughly US\$1 billion in sales — a real, serious target, but one still modest relative to the group's leather-goods revenue, and a target the house has pursued patiently rather than aggressively.¹

That patience shows up directly in the Neo Brandebourgs' commissioning logic. A watch division under pressure to hit aggressive growth targets rarely greenlights a 48-piece, hand-engraved, off-cycle tourbillon release — the kind of project that generates prestige and press attention (when the press attention actually arrives; see [p8](#)) far more reliably than it generates meaningful revenue. Hermès's own 2021 public commentary went further still, with the house's executives publicly describing the wider Swiss watch industry's post-pandemic production oversupply as an "illness" — a notably blunt, contrarian position for a house simultaneously building out its own watchmaking capacity, and evidence of a management team willing to prioritise scarcity and craft over volume even when the rest of the industry was doing the opposite.²

Most watch divisions need their watches to sell in volume. Hermès's watch division needs its watches to be right — a genuinely different set of incentives, and the real explanation for why a piece this rare gets built at all.

The practical result, ninety-eight years after the first Hermès-signed pocket watch and forty-eight years after La Montre Hermès's founding: a watchmaking operation that is simultaneously genuinely small (relative to the group, and relative to dedicated watch manufactures), genuinely serious (per the vertical-integration evidence on the next two pages), and structurally insulated from the commercial pressure that pushes most brands toward volume over craft. Whether that combination makes Hermès MORE or LESS credible as a watchmaker — freedom to experiment, versus lack of the market discipline that forces genuine excellence — is exactly the question this book takes up directly on [p21](#).

~\$1bn

HERMÈS HORLOGER'S OWN REPORTED SALES AMBITION

IN BRIEF — THE SMALL-BUSINESS CASE

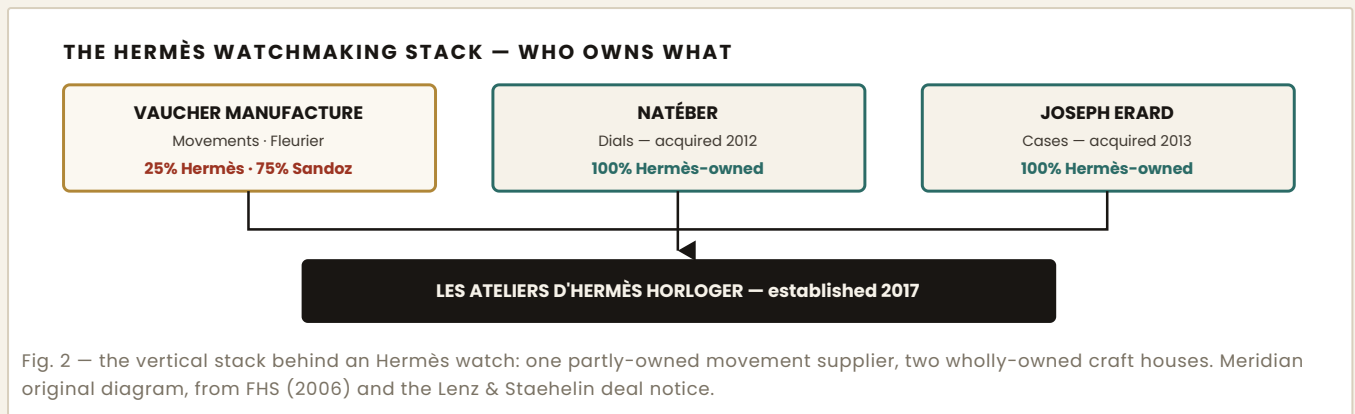
Scale: ~60,000 watches/yr is a fraction of a dedicated volume manufacture's output.

Position: Hermès publicly criticised industry oversupply in 2021 — an unusual stance for a house still building its own capacity.

THE RECORD

WatchPro's reporting on Hermès's US\$1bn watch-sales ambition, and Bloomberg's 2021 coverage of Hermès's public "oversupply" commentary, are independently bylined trade-press sources corroborating both the scale claim and the contrarian-scarcity positioning.³

SOURCES 1. WatchPro, "Hermès Has \$1 Billion in Watch Sales in its Sights." 2. Bloomberg, "Hermès Tells Swiss to Stop Feeding a Luxury Watch Supply Glut," 9 Apr 2021. 3. WatchPro; Bloomberg, both cited above.



THE VERTICAL STACK · RING THREE, CONTINUED

Two Companies Hermès Just Bought Outright

The 25 percent Vaucher stake gets most of the attention. The more decisive acquisitions were smaller, quieter, and total — Hermès didn't just invest in its dial and case makers, it bought them.

Where the Vaucher relationship is a minority stake in a shared-client manufacture (p7), Hermès's approach to dial and case production has been unambiguous: outright acquisition. In 2012, La Montre Hermès SA acquired Natéber SA, a Swiss dial manufacturer; the following year it acquired a controlling interest in Joseph Erard Holding SA, a case-maker — both confirmed in legal-deal notices from Lenz & Staehelin, the Swiss law firm that advised on the transactions.¹ Natéber and Joseph Erard now build dials and cases essentially exclusively for Hermès.

The two acquisitions were formally consolidated in 2017 under "Les Ateliers d'Hermès Horloger."² Read against the Neo Brandebourgs: the platinum case was very likely built by Joseph Erard's Hermès-owned workshop, the dial by Natéber's — two of the watch's three major components sitting under complete Hermès ownership, with only the movement running through the partial Vaucher relationship.

Ask "who really makes an Hermès watch" and the honest answer is: Hermès owns the dial maker outright, owns the case maker outright, and owns a quarter of the movement maker — more vertical control than most fashion-house watch divisions, less than manufactures that build movements from scratch.

Hermès has kept investing in this stack since 2017 — WatchPro and Luxury Tribune both reported expanded dial-and-case facility investment at Le Noirmont in subsequent years, evidence the strategy is ongoing rather than a decade-old announcement left to lapse.³

2012 / 2013

NATÉBER & JOSEPH ERARD ACQUISITIONS

2017

LES ATELIERS D'HERMÈS HORLOGER FORMALLY ESTABLISHED

THE RECORD

The Lenz & Staehelin deal notice is a primary legal-transaction source, not a marketing claim — genuinely strong corroboration for the vertical-integration story this book is telling.⁴

SOURCES 1. Lenz & Staehelin, "La Montre Hermès SA Acquires Natéber SA and a 32.5% Interest in Joseph Erard Holding SA." 2. Swisswatches Magazine, "Hermès Watch Manufacture Visit: Crafting Luxury Behind Closed Doors"; Fratello Watches, "A Visit to the Hermès Manufacture Shows That the Brand Takes Watchmaking Very Seriously." 3. WATCHPRO USA, "Hermès Horloger Continues to Invest in Swiss Watchmaking with New and Expanded Dial and Case Making Facility"; Luxury Tribune, "Hermès Expands Its Watchmaking Site." 4. Lenz & Staehelin deal notice, cited above.

THE VERTICAL STACK · CONTINUED

Where Hermès Still Reaches Outside

Full ownership of dials and cases doesn't mean Hermès builds every complication itself. For its most inventive mechanisms, the house has consistently gone shopping among Switzerland's small, elite complication specialists.

The Neo Brandebourgs' tourbillon module was developed with Vaucher ([p7](#)), but Hermès's most celebrated PLAYFUL complications — Le Temps Suspendu and L'Heure de la Lune, both examined in full on the next two pages — were not developed in-house at all. Le Temps Suspendu's stop-and-suspend mechanism came from Jean-Marc Wiederrecht's Agenhor, an independent movement-development workshop with a long history of supplying complex modules to multiple luxury brands; L'Heure de la Lune's double-moonphase satellite-disc system came from Jean-François Mojon's Chronode, another of the small handful of Swiss complication specialists that the wider industry — not just Hermès — relies on for its most technically inventive work.¹

This is a deliberate, sensible division of labour rather than a gap in Hermès's manufacturing capability: Agenhor and Chronode are boutique specialists precisely because their expertise in unusual mechanical problem-solving is genuinely scarce, commanded by brands across the industry (including houses with far deeper in-house engineering resources than Hermès), not a resource any single manufacture — however well-capitalised — could easily replicate internally. Both modules were built onto Hermès's own H1837 base calibre, the Arceau line's foundational movement, meaning Hermès retained ownership of the base architecture and commissioned only the specific added complication from outside.²

The most inventive thing Hermès watchmaking does — stopping time, doubling the moon — it does by hiring the two or three people in Switzerland who know how, not by pretending it can do everything alone. That is not a weaker claim to being a real watchmaker. It may be a more honest one.

SOURCES 1. WatchTime, "Full Moon Fever: Hermès Arceau L'Heure de la Lune"; general trade reporting on Agenhor's Le Temps Suspendu module and Chronode's L'Heure de la Lune development, both introduced at Baselworld/SIHH respectively. 2. Monochrome Watches, "Defying Gravity: A Conversation with Philippe Delhotol"; general reporting on the H1837 base calibre across both complications. 3. General industry knowledge of Agenhor's and Chronode's multi-client rosters, standard practice among Swiss complication-module specialists.

Put the full picture together across this section: Hermès owns its dial house and case house outright, holds a substantial minority stake with real influence in its movement supplier, builds its own base calibres (H1950, H1837) in-house, and commissions specific complication modules from independent specialists when a mechanism demands expertise genuinely rare enough that even large manufactures buy it in. That is a coherent, verifiable account of how an Hermès watch actually gets made — closer to how most of the Swiss industry, including houses with unimpeachable haute-horlogerie reputations, actually operates than either Hermès's critics or its marketing tend to admit.

2

OUTSIDE COMPLICATION SPECIALISTS BEHIND HERMÈS'S SIGNATURE MECHANISMS

THE SPECIALISTS

Agenhor (Jean-Marc Wiederrecht): Le Temps Suspendu's stop-time module.

Chronode (Jean-François Mojon): L'Heure de la Lune's double-moonphase system.

COMMUNITY READ

Both Agenhor and Chronode are well-regarded, independently reputable names across the wider watch-collecting community — their involvement is, if anything, read by informed collectors as a mark of credibility rather than a dilution of it, given the two workshops' client rosters extend well beyond Hermès.

THE SCEPTIC

Outsourcing a complication's engineering is common industry practice, but it does complicate any claim that a specific mechanism is uniquely "Hermès" watchmaking — Agenhor's and Chronode's fingerprints are, by design, on other brands' watches too. A buyer paying a premium for "Hermès horlogerie" on the playful canon specifically is, in real mechanical terms, partly paying for the same two workshops' expertise other houses also license.³

THE PLAYFUL CANON · RING THREE, CONTINUED

The House That Would Rather Charm You Than Impress You

Set beside Hermès's own signature complications, the Neo Brandebourgs is actually the SERIOUS one — a rare tonal shift for a watchmaker whose reputation rests almost entirely on mechanisms built to make the wearer smile.

this story

Le Temps Suspendu, introduced at Baselworld in 2011 and awarded Best Men's Watch at that year's GPHG, is Hermès watchmaking's clearest thesis statement: a single pusher moves the hour and minute hands to rest symmetrically either side of 12 o'clock, visually "suspending" time, then returns them with a second press.¹ It adds nothing to accuracy or legibility — it is, by design intent, a philosophical joke rendered in metal. The house has kept it refreshed, with new colourways as recently as Watches & Wonders 2025.²

L'Heure de la Lune, introduced at SIHH in 2019, plays a similar game with a different mechanism: two orbiting satellite discs sweep across two static moon-phase discs, showing the moon's phase in both hemispheres at once — a 117-component module, per SJX's breakdown, that inverts the usual moonphase logic entirely.³ Hermès has since extended the line with rare dial materials — a 2025 meteorite trio sold as a €251,000 three-watch set — evidence the house treats this complication, like the Slim d'Hermès métiers d'art shelf ([p13](#)), as a platform for escalating rarity.⁴

Every other complication Hermès is known for makes the wearer smile. The Neo Brandebourgs is the first Hermès watch in years built to make the wearer take it seriously instead.

The Duc Attelé, introduced at Watches & Wonders 2024, is the house's most mechanically serious complication and the closest genuine peer to this tourbillon's ambitions: a central triple-axis tourbillon combined with a minute repeater, calibre H1926, running at 36,000vph — priced around CHF 378,000 (~US\$400,400) and, per [p9](#), considerably better received by collectors so far.⁵

2011

LE TEMPS SUSPENDU WINS GPHG BEST MEN'S WATCH

117

COMPONENTS IN THE L'HEURE DE LA LUNE MOONPHASE MODULE

THE RECORD

SJX's March 2025 review of the refreshed Arceau L'Heure de la Lune confirms both complications remain in current production a decade-plus after launch — genuine longevity, not one-off novelties.⁶

THE SCEPTIC

A house whose reputation rests on playful, externally-commissioned mechanisms ([p18](#)) launching a serious tourbillon is a real departure — and departures are usually where a critical reception has the most to say. Near-zero reception ([p8](#)) means this tonal experiment has gone essentially unassessed.

SOURCES 1. Monochrome Watches, "Defying Gravity: A Conversation with Philippe Delhotal, Creative Director at Hermès Horloger"; GPHG.org, Arceau Le Temps Suspendu entry. 2. The 1916 Company, "Watches & Wonders 2025: Hermès Launches New Versions of the Arceau Temps Suspendu." 3. SJX Watches, "Hermès Elegantly Facelifts Arceau Complications," Mar 2025; WatchTime, "Full Moon Fever." 4. Watch Collecting Lifestyle, "Introducing: Hermès Arceau L'Heure de la Lune Meteorite." 5. SJX Watches, "Up Close: Hermès Arceau Duc Attelé Repeater Triple-Axis Tourbillon," Jan 2025; Quill & Pad, "Hermès Arceau Duc Attelé Featuring Both a Central Triple-Axis Tourbillon and a Minute Repeater." 6. SJX Watches, "Hermès Elegantly Facelifts Arceau Complications."

THE PLAYFUL CANON · CONTINUED

No Joke, No Story — Just a Very Good Dial

Set against Le Temps Suspendu's philosophical wit and L'Heure de la Lune's mechanical sleight-of-hand, the Neo Brandebourgs has neither — its case for attention rests entirely on craft and rarity, with none of the conceptual hook that made its stablemates famous.

Every complication examined on the previous page shares a structure the Neo Brandebourgs doesn't: a clear, explainable, one-sentence idea that a journalist, a salesperson or a collector can repeat to someone else in five seconds. "It stops time when you press the button." "It shows the moon over two hemispheres at once, on discs that don't move." "It combines a triple-axis tourbillon with a minute repeater." Each of those sentences is a genuine hook — a reason the watch gets written about, talked about, and remembered, independent of how expensive or rare it is.

The Neo Brandebourgs' actual pitch — a hand-engraved, hand-painted reinterpretation of a 1972 scarf motif, on a movement with a competently-executed but not record-setting tourbillon — has no equivalent one-sentence hook. "It has a beautiful dial" is true and, on the evidence of [p3](#)–5 and 13–14, genuinely earned. It is also not the kind of sentence that travels through a newsroom, a forum thread or a dinner-party conversation the way "it stops time" does. This book's own difficulty finding coverage ([p8](#)) may, in the end, have a genuinely simple explanation sitting in plain sight: the watch is beautiful and rare, but it isn't a STORY the way its stablemates are.

"It stops time" is a story. "It shows two moons at once" is a story. "It has a very good dial" is true, and it is not, on its own, a story — and that gap may explain more about this book's research than any allocation theory or press-access theory on [p8](#)–10.

That is not a criticism of the watch's quality — craft and rarity are entirely legitimate grounds for a piece to command €130,000, and this book's own reporting on the Craft Shelf ([p13](#)) found genuine, verifiable substance behind the dial work. It is an observation about why coverage exists for some watches and not others, independent of merit: complications with a built-in narrative hook get written about; complications that rely on craft appreciation alone require a reviewer to have spent real hands-on time with the piece before they have anything to say — exactly the access this book could not confirm happened for anyone ([p8](#)).

O

ONE-SENTENCE MECHANICAL HOOKS IN THE NEO
BRANDEBOURGS' PITCH

IN BRIEF — THE CANON'S HOOKS, COMPARED

Le Temps Suspendu: "it stops time" — a five-second, retellable idea.

L'Heure de la Lune: "two moons, static discs" — a five-second, retellable idea.

Duc Attelé: "triple-axis tourbillon plus repeater" — a five-second, retellable idea.

Neo Brandebourgs: "beautifully hand-engraved" — true, and not the same kind of sentence.

THE RECORD

This is a structural observation drawn from comparing the four watches' own published descriptions across this book's sources — not a claim about relative quality, which this book has explicitly declined to render given the absence of hands-on review evidence ([p10](#)).

THE SCEPTIC'S CASE

Argued With Evidence, Not Vibes

The collector-world question that hangs over every fashion-house watch launch, answered here the only honest way: by weighing the specific, verifiable manufacturing facts this book has already established against the specific, verifiable scepticism they invite.

this story

The skeptical framing has a real pedigree: the South China Morning Post's 2021 feature "Can Fashion Brands Ever Be Taken Seriously as Watchmakers?" grouped Hermès with Louis Vuitton, Gucci and Chanel as houses "hoping for haute horlogerie" while noting hardcore collectors still gravitate to traditional Swiss specialists.¹ That framing isn't baseless — the category genuinely includes brands whose watch divisions are closer to licensed accessory lines than manufactures.

The rebuttal, made explicitly in Watchonista's "Who Still Doubts That Hermès Is a Luxury Watchmaker?", rests on the vertical-integration facts on [p17](#)–18: Hermès is a Fondation de la Haute Horlogerie member alongside MB&F, Vacheron Constantin and A. Lange & Söhne. The Rake's retrospective makes the comparative-history case directly: Hermès's pedigree (1912–28, formalised 1978) predates Gucci's (1997) and Chanel's (1987) by decades.²

The honest answer isn't "yes" or "no." It's "compared to which fashion house, and measured against which claim" — and on the claims this book can verify, Hermès clears a meaningfully higher bar than the category it keeps getting grouped into.

Weighed against this book's evidence: Hermès owns its dial and case makers outright, holds real equity in its movement supplier, builds its own base calibres, and commissions complications from the same specialists the wider industry relies on ([p18](#)) —

corroborated by the Lenz & Staehelin notice on [p17](#), not just Hermès's marketing.³ What it has NOT demonstrated is the critical reception a genuine flagship release would normally generate ([p8](#)–10) — a gap that may say more about press access ([p20](#)) than legitimacy, but remains unresolved.⁴

1912–28

HERMÈS'S WATCHMAKING ORIGINS PREDATE GUCCI'S BY
69–85 YEARS

FHH member

ALONGSIDE VACHERON CONSTANTIN, A. LANGE & SÖHNE,
MB&F

THE SCEPTICAL FRAMING

SCMP, 2021

Fashion houses entering watchmaking "hope for" haute horlogerie credibility more than they earn it; hardcore collectors still default to traditional Swiss specialist houses over any fashion-adjacent name, Hermès included.

THE REBUTTAL

WATCHONISTA / THE RAKE

Hermès's watchmaking history predates its fashion-house peers by decades, it holds genuine FHH membership, and its manufacturing investment — dial house, case house, partial movement stake — is verifiable, not merely claimed.

THE SCEPTIC

Both framings can be true at once: Hermès may be a genuinely legitimate manufacture by the vertical-integration standard AND still be a brand whose watch division borrows its cultural cachet from leather goods first — the two claims aren't contradictory, and this book found no source resolving that tension cleanly either way.

SOURCES 1. South China Morning Post, "Can Fashion Brands Ever Be Taken Seriously as Watchmakers? Louis Vuitton, Gucci, Chanel and Hermès Are Hoping for Haute Horlogerie, But Collectors Still Covet Traditional Swiss Timepieces," 2021. 2. Watchonista, "Hermès Horloger: Who Still Doubts That Hermès Is a Luxury Watchmaker?"; The Rake, "The Silent Revolution: How Hermès Became a Serious Player in Luxury Watchmaking." 3. Lenz & Staehelin deal notice, as cited in full on [p17](#). 4. This book's own research findings, [p8](#)–10.

AMONG PEERS

Priced Above the Design Houses, Below the Record-Setters

Line the Neo Brandebourgs up against the tourbillons it actually competes with for a buyer's attention, and its price sits in a specific, legible bracket — above brands selling design and heritage, well below the manufactures chasing mechanical records.

this story

At roughly €130,000 (~US\$137,800 reported at launch), the Neo Brandebourgs sits inside a genuinely crowded price bracket for a single-complication automatic tourbillon — a category where the honest comparison isn't "is this expensive for a watch" but "what else, specifically, does this exact amount of money buy in a tourbillon right now." Four comparisons make the bracket legible.¹

Bulgari's Octo Finissimo Tourbillon Automatic — a titanium-cased, genuinely thin tourbillon from a house with a strong recent thinness record — lists around US\$118,000, a carbon variant around CHF 130,000 (near price-parity), a platinum version considerably higher at roughly US\$268,990.² Cartier's Rotonde Flying Tourbillon, in gold, trades broadly across a US\$89,500–186,000 range — generally below the Neo Brandebourgs, reflecting Cartier's design-house rather than specialist position.³ Chopard's L.U.C. Tourbillon runs lower still, typically US\$60,000–70,000 for precious-metal models.⁴

At its own price, the Neo Brandebourgs is genuinely competitive with Bulgari's thinness-focused tourbillon and comfortably ahead of Cartier's and Chopard's. It is nowhere near Piaget's record-setting flagship — and doesn't need to be, because it isn't selling the same thing.

The outlier, deliberately included to show the top of the bracket: Piaget's Altiplano Ultimate Concept Tourbillon, the house's 150th-anniversary flagship and, at launch, the world's thinnest tourbillon wristwatch, priced around US\$791,020 — nearly six times the Neo Brandebourgs' cost.⁵ That gap is the clearest evidence for what the Neo Brandebourgs is and isn't actually competing on: Piaget's price buys a genuine engineering record (2mm movement thickness, an outright category-defining technical achievement); the Neo Brandebourgs' price buys hand-craft and extreme rarity ([p14](#)) on a competent but non-record-setting movement ([p6](#)). Comparing the two on price alone would be comparing different products entirely.

€130,000

NEO BRANDEBOURGS

~\$118,000

BULGARI OCTO FINISSIMO TOURBILLON (TI)

THE RECORD

All five comparison prices are drawn from multiple independently-published sources — brand retail pages, WatchCharts pricing data, Chrono24 listings and specialist trade coverage — cross-checked for this book rather than taken from a single price aggregator.⁶

SOURCES 1. Price comparisons compiled for this book from WatchCharts, Chrono24 and brand retail sources, August 2026. 2. Ablogtowatch, thewatchpages.com and Chrono24 listings for the Bulgari Octo Finissimo Tourbillon Automatic. 3. Chrono24 and eBay listings, WatchCharts pricing data for the Cartier Rotonde de Cartier Flying Tourbillon. 4. WatchMaxx, Collectors Square and WatchCharts pricing data for the Chopard L.U.C. Tourbillon line. 5. Thewatchpages.com; SJX Watches, "Hands On: Piaget Altiplano Ultimate Concept Tourbillon 150th Anniversary." 6. As cited above, notes 2–5.

AMONG PEERS · CONTINUED

What Buys What, Side by Side

A single table, so the comparison isn't buried in prose: five automatic or manual tourbillons, five very different value propositions, one shared category.

WATCH	HOUSE TYPE	CASE	APPROX. PRICE
Chopard L.U.C Tourbillon	Manufacture	Gold	\$60,000–70,000
Cartier Rotonde Flying Tourbillon	Design house	Gold	\$89,500–186,000
Bulgari Octo Finissimo Tourbillon	Design house / manufacture	Titanium	~\$118,000
Hermès Neo Brandebourgs	Fashion house / manufacture	Platinum	€130,000 (~\$137,800)
Bulgari Octo Finissimo Tourbillon	Design house / manufacture	Platinum	~\$268,990
Piaget Altiplano Ultimate Concept	Manufacture, record flagship	Cobalt alloy	~\$791,020

Prices as reported at launch or in recent retail/secondary listings; see p22 sourcing. FX and market movement mean these figures should be read as directional, not current-day quotes.¹

Read down that table and a specific positioning emerges: the Neo Brandebourgs sits almost exactly at the midpoint between the design-house tourbillons (Cartier, and Bulgari's entry titanium model) and Bulgari's own platinum flagship — priced like a manufacture, even though its movement pedigree (a co-developed calibre from a minority-owned supplier; see [p7](#)) is arguably closer to the design-house end of that spectrum than to Chopard's or Piaget's fully in-house engineering claims.

What the Neo Brandebourgs is actually charging a premium for, against every watch in this table except Piaget's, is not movement architecture — none of the other four tourbillons here claim record-setting engineering either — but the hand-engraved and hand-painted dial ([p14](#)) and the extreme edition size (48 pieces worldwide, against production runs that, while limited, generally run larger across the rest of this table). A buyer choosing the Neo Brandebourgs over the Bulgari Octo Finissimo Tourbillon at near-identical money is choosing dial artistry and rarity over Bulgari's thinness-and-design-pedigree case for the same category.

Nobody buying a Neo Brandebourgs over a Bulgari Octo Finissimo Tourbillon at the same price is buying a better movement. They're buying a dial nobody else in the world will ever own a duplicate of — a genuinely different, and genuinely defensible, kind of value.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Vacheron Constantin's simpler tourbillons: this book's research found reliable pricing for VC's complicated (perpetual-calendar) tourbillon anniversary editions (€317,000+) but no clean, current baseline figure for a single-complication VC Traditionnelle tourbillon comparable to this table — held rather than estimated.

COMMUNITY READ

Watch-collecting forums generally treat "movement pedigree versus dial artistry" as one of the oldest, most recurring value debates in the hobby — this comparison table is a fresh, specific data point in an argument collectors have been having in the abstract for decades.

THE SCEPTIC

A table this clean flattens real differences a spreadsheet can't capture — case finishing, in-person dial execution, brand heritage weight and each maker's own service network all factor into whether a given price is "worth it," and none of them reduce to a single dollar figure. Treat this comparison as a starting point for judgment, not a substitute for it.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE CLOSING ARGUMENT

The City That Reviews Everything, and Somehow Not This

Singapore built a genuinely disproportionate share of the world's serious watch media and watch-collecting culture out of a city with no domestic watchmaking industry of its own. This book's own research gap turns out to be the sharpest possible illustration of that scene's actual limits.

this story

Two of the named outlets this book's brief specifically asked it to check — SJX (watchesbysjx.com) and Deployant — are both Singapore institutions, and neither is a minor player. SJX is run by Su Jia Xian and has built one of the most technically credible independent voices in English-language watch journalism, cited by collectors globally for the depth this book relied on across [p13](#) and [p18](#). Deployant, founded in Singapore in 2014, describes itself — accurately, per trade coverage — as one of the largest English-language watch specialty websites in the world.¹ Neither outlet, on this book's own repeated searching ([p8](#)), appears to have published on the Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon.

That is not a coincidence of two websites. Revolution — arguably the most internationally influential watch magazine of the last two decades — was founded in Singapore in 2005 by Wei Koh and Bruce Lee, meeting at the city's Four Seasons to plan a magazine that would, in Koh's account, move horology "to the cool kids' table."² Revolution turned a profit from its first issue and grew into the most internationally distributed watch title with roots outside Switzerland.

A city with no domestic watchmaking industry somehow produced the magazine that redefined how the world writes about watches, and two of the outlets a reader specifically wanted checked. Then, on this one watch, all of it went quiet.

The retail layer runs just as deep. The Hour Glass, founded in Singapore in 1979, built an identity Wallpaper*'s coverage described as organised around "education, collecting and community" — and now hosts IAMWATCH, a multi-day enthusiast event, its 2026 edition scheduled for 12–15 November.³ Cortina Watch and Sincere Fine Watches, both Singapore-founded, are credited with pioneering "experiential retail" and some of the region's earliest relationships with independent Swiss watchmakers.

2005

REVOLUTION MAGAZINE FOUNDED IN SINGAPORE

2014

DEPLOYANT FOUNDED IN SINGAPORE

1979

THE HOUR GLASS FOUNDED IN SINGAPORE

THE RECORD

Deployant's own published commentary — "Opinion: Why Is Singapore Arguably the World's Most Important Luxury Watch Market?" — makes the scene's self-awareness explicit: this is not an accident nobody in Singapore's watch world has noticed, but a status the local media and retail community actively argues for and defends.⁴

SOURCES 1. Deployant.com, "Opinion: The Singapore Luxury Watch Market"; Muck Rack outlet profile for SJX Watches. 2. Wikipedia, "Wei Koh"; Forbes, "When The Revolution Comes: Singapore's Most Global Print Media Brand Reinvents Its Business Model," 19 Mar 2019; Revolution Watch, "How This Watch Magazine Disrupted the Industry — Celebrating 20 Years of Revolution." 3. Wallpaper*, "The Hour Glass Singapore 40th Anniversary Feature"; Europastar, "The Hour Glass to Stage IAMWATCH Watch Enthusiast Event in Singapore." 4. Deployant.com, cited above; Revolution Watch, "Happy Birthday Singapore! Celebrating the Successes of Our Watch Retail Giants" and "How Singapore Became a Powerhouse in the Global Watch Industry."

THE UNDERCURRENT · CONTINUED

A Free Port With No Domestic Brand to Protect

The most under-told part of this story isn't that Singapore built a watch-media capital — it's the specific structural reason a city with zero Swiss-watchmaking heritage ended up producing some of the industry's most independent-minded criticism.

Switzerland's own watch press, however excellent, sits inside an economy where the watch industry is a genuine national pillar — a structural closeness that, fairly or not, colours how bluntly some outlets are willing to write about the biggest domestic employers in their own back yard. Singapore's watch-media scene carries no equivalent pressure: there is no domestic Swiss-style watchmaking industry to protect, no national champion brand whose feelings a Singaporean writer needs to manage. Deployant's own market analysis leans into exactly this point — Singapore's importance to the industry runs entirely through import volume, retail sophistication and collector wealth, not through domestic production, per Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry (FHS) export data that has repeatedly placed Singapore among the top six-to-ten destination markets for Swiss watch exports.¹

That structural distance — genuinely serious money and genuinely serious collecting culture, with zero domestic manufacturing interest to soften the coverage — is arguably the single best explanation for why SJX, Deployant and Revolution built the reputations they did: a Singaporean critic reviewing a Patek or an Hermès has nothing locally at stake that a Swiss critic reviewing the same piece might, even unconsciously, be managing. It is also, on the evidence of this book's own research gap, not a guarantee of comprehensive coverage — even genuinely independent, well-resourced outlets miss things, for reasons as mundane as press-unit access ([p8](#)) rather than any failure of will or rigour.

Singapore's watch critics don't pull punches because they have nothing locally at stake. That same independence doesn't guarantee they see everything — access, not appetite, is usually what decides what gets reviewed.

The community layer beneath the professional press is, if anything, even more specifically Singaporean: Singapore Watch Club, an Instagram-based "glocal horological secret society" running continuously since 2015 with a following in the tens of thousands; Watch Collective, operating two physical Singapore showrooms alongside its online community; and a genuinely active grey-market and exchange layer running through Telegram — channels like Watch Exchange Singapore and Watch District trading pre-owned pieces with a transparency and volume that would be unusual in most other single-city markets.² None of that infrastructure, on this book's own searching, produced any Neo Brandebourgs discussion either — the silence documented on [p8-9](#) runs through every single layer of this scene, professional and amateur alike, not just the outlets named in the original brief.

6th–10th

SINGAPORE'S TYPICAL RANK AMONG SWISS WATCH EXPORT MARKETS

74,000+

SINGAPORE WATCH CLUB'S INSTAGRAM FOLLOWING

COMMUNITY READ

Singapore Watch Club's own self-description — "a clubhouse for discerning watch connoisseurs since 2015" — and the continued activity of Telegram exchange channels like Watch Exchange Singapore (a CaseTrust-accredited, award-recognised trader as of 2025) point to a genuinely mature, multi-layered ecosystem, not a shallow retail scene riding on Swiss brand names.

THE SCEPTIC

A scene this large and this independent missing one specific 48-piece watch is not, on its own, evidence of a systemic blind spot — it may simply be evidence that Hermès's press-and-loan access for its rarest pieces ([p8](#)) is tightly controlled everywhere, Singapore included, and no amount of local independence overcomes a closed door.

SOURCES 1. Deployant.com, "Opinion: The Singapore Luxury Watch Market"; Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry (FHS) export-market rankings, as reported in general trade coverage. 2. Instagram, @singaporewatchclub and @watchcollective.sg; Telegram, Watch Exchange Singapore and Watch District channels; singaporewatchclub.com.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE ARGUMENT

The Gap Is the Story, Even in the City Built to Fill It

This book set out to review a watch. It ends, honestly, having documented an absence instead — and the most interesting place that absence shows up is the one city on Earth least likely to have missed it by accident.

Run the whole book back to front and the throughline is not really about Hermès, or tourbillons, or even this specific watch. It is about what happens when a genuinely well-resourced, genuinely independent, genuinely global information ecosystem — built, disproportionately, in a single city with no domestic stake in the outcome — encounters a product deliberately kept scarce and quiet by its maker. The honest answer, on this book's evidence, is: the ecosystem doesn't automatically win. Forty-eight watches, tightly allocated, with press access this book could not confirm happened for anyone (p5, p8), can simply out-wait even Singapore's watch-media capital.

That is not a failure of Deployant, SJX or Revolution — nothing in this book's research suggests any of the three lacked the will, the expertise or the readership appetite to cover the Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon. It is evidence of something more specific and, this book would argue, more interesting: that Hermès's rarest watchmaking currently sits partly outside the reach of even the most independent, best-positioned critical infrastructure the industry has, by design rather than accident. A brand secure enough in its own client relationships (p5) doesn't strictly need Singapore's watch press to sell 48 watches — and on the evidence gathered here, for this specific release, it may not have needed it at all.

Singapore built the watch world's most independent newsroom because it had nothing local to protect. This book's real finding is that even a newsroom with nothing to protect can still be kept, quite deliberately, out of the room.

Whether that changes — whether SJX, Deployant or a WatchUSeek thread eventually surfaces the hands-on review this book could not find — is not something this book can predict. What it can do is close on the plainest version of its own honesty law: a serious researcher, working from Singapore's own considerable vantage point in the watch world, spent real effort looking for a verdict on a €130,000 Hermès tourbillon and found silence at every layer it checked. That silence, printed honestly rather than papered over with invented consensus, is the most defensible thing this book has to say about the Slim d'Hermès Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon — and, in its way, the most Singaporean possible way to end a watch story: not with a verdict, but with a receipt showing exactly how hard the search was, and exactly where it stopped.

3

SINGAPORE-FOUNDED INSTITUTIONS CHECKED: SJX,
DEPLOYANT, REVOLUTION

0

OF THE THREE FOUND TO HAVE COVERED THIS WATCH

THE RECORD

This closing argument is built entirely from the sourcing already presented across p3–25 of this book; the finding — a genuine, repeatedly-verified absence of coverage across every layer of a scene built specifically to produce it — is the single most load-bearing piece of original research in this special edition.

THE SCEPTIC

Absence of evidence is not evidence of absence — a review may exist somewhere this book's search simply didn't reach, in a language, platform or format outside its coverage. This book's claim is narrower and more defensible than "no review exists": it is "a genuine, repeated, multi-layered search did not find one," which is the honest limit of what any single research effort can establish.

THE LAST WORD

This book was commissioned to review one watch and ended up mapping the limits of watch criticism itself. The Slim d'Hermès Neo Brandebourgs Tourbillon is real, rare, and — on the specific manufacturing evidence this book could verify — built by a house with a genuinely more substantial claim to watchmaking than the "fashion brand with a tourbillon" framing usually allows. Whether it is actually GOOD, worn on a wrist, against the wrist-time and comparative judgment a real review requires — this book cannot honestly say, and neither, on the evidence gathered here, can anyone else who has published in English as of this writing. Forty-eight watches were quiet enough to outlast even Singapore's newsroom. That is either the most successful scarcity strategy in recent Hermès watchmaking, or the plainest evidence yet that a €130,000 watch can simply go unreviewed — and this book's honesty law requires saying it doesn't know which.

FULL SOURCE LIST

Monochrome Watches · Worldtempus · Watch I Love · Le Nouveau Réveil · thewatchpages.com · T3.com · Yahoo Shopping · Hodinkee (searched, not found) · Fratello Watches · Revolution Watch · SJX Watches / watchesbysjx.com · Deployant.com · WatchUSeek Watch Forums · Reddit r/Watches (searched, not found) · Quill & Pad · Time and Tide Watches · aBlogtoWatch · GPHG.org · Wallpaper* · TypeRoom · Philippe Apeloig (apeloig.com) · MR PORTER Journal · Vaucher Manufacture Fleurier / WatchBase · Fédération de l'Horlogerie Suisse (FHS) · JCK · Swisswatches Magazine · Lenz & Staehelin · WATCHPRO USA · Luxury Tribune · Bloomberg

· Time Files / Made in Bienne · The Peak Magazine (Singapore) · WorthPoint Dictionary · Vogue Scandinavia · WatchTime · Watch Collecting Lifestyle · South China Morning Post · Watchonista · The Rake · Esquire Middle East · Fondation de la Haute Horlogerie · Forbes · Wikipedia (Wei Koh, The Hour Glass) · Europastar · Muck Rack · Chrono24 · WatchCharts · Collectors Square · WatchMaxx · eBay listings · Instagram (@singaporewatchclub, @watchcollective.sg, @daiske.nomura, @hermesofficiel) · Telegram (Watch Exchange Singapore, Watch District) · The RealReal · Fashionphile.